ARES Sync - Technician Rollout Installation and Teacher Handoff

Use this guide when an ARES technician or ARES Advocate prepares a school server, then helps a teacher install and enroll ARES Sync.

For a short components-and-process handout, use

docs/pdf/ARES_Offline_Installer_Overview.pdf in the completed installer bundle.

Before a whole-disk reload, follow docs/PRE_RELOAD_PRESERVATION.md.

What changed for offline school installations

The approved production ARES Sync APK is now bundled into the ARES Q4 Offline package and copied to the school server. A teacher connected to the school ARES network can install the app without Internet access by opening:

http://ares.local/app_install/index.html

The direct APK is also available at:

http://ares.local/downloads/ares-sync.apk

The local install page is intentionally named app_install rather than a generic install path to reduce accidental discovery by users who do not need to install the app.

Keep index.html in the link. Some ARES servers route directory addresses through

the file manager; the explicit filename opens the installation page directly.

The administrator can use /app_install/index.html for an entry at the end of

the teacher section. Adding that menu entry is a separate server-content edit.

The one-time installation key is still supplied by ARES staff. Installing the APK itself does not require Internet. If the current ARES Sync enrollment process needs to contact the central ARES enrollment service, normal Internet or mobile data is required when the teacher enrolls the phone.

Before visiting the teacher

- Use the centrally approved ARES Q4 Offline field ZIP. Do not assemble a school package from individual files.

- Confirm the school server's existing usage report works and that you have administrator access.

- Confirm the canonical school name and ARES-S00XX ID.

- Obtain or be able to generate the teacher's one-time installation key from the protected ARES staff enrollment system.

- Use the normal master command below; it checks the package and prerequisites automatically.

Obtain the school ID before the visit

Use an Internet-connected staff computer or phone to open:

https://areseducation.org/monitor_upload/staff_enrollment.php

1. Sign in with the shared **ARES staff enrollment password** supplied by ARES administration.
2. Search for the school by name.
3. Confirm the canonical school name and the displayed **School ID**, such as ARES-S0035.
4. Record that ID on the installation worksheet and use the same ID in the server installer command. ARES-S00XX in this guide is a placeholder, not an assigned ID.
5. If the school is missing, ask ARES administration to register it and assign its ID before phone enrollment. Do not invent an ID or reuse another school's ID.

The **School ID** is permanent and identifies the school/server. The

installation key is a separate, one-time XXXX-XXXX value for one phone.

Looking up the School ID does not require generating an installation key.

Obtain the School ID before travelling; the server can then be installed offline.

Central phone enrollment still needs Internet or mobile data.

On an already configured school server, check its stored ID with:

sudo grep '^SCHOOL_CODE=' /etc/ares/usage-upload.conf

Confirm that it matches the portal's ID for the intended school. A restored image

may contain another school's ID. If the code is provisional or incorrect, have

ARES support confirm the assignment, then run sudo ares-set-school-code ARES-S00XX

with the final ID. Continue to phone enrollment only after reassignment succeeds.

1. Install and verify the school server

The full installer below includes LAN desktop support. ARES_v1.13_LAN_Desktop_Update_20261106.zip updates older installed servers only; you do not need both ZIPs for a full installation.

1 Copy ARES_Q4_Offline_v0.94_amd64_v1.13_20261106.zip to the server and extract that full installer into a new folder.

2 Open a terminal in the extracted ARES_Q4_Offline_... directory and run:

sudo bash install_offline.sh ARES-S00XX

Replace ARES-S00XX with the school's final or approved provisional code.

The installer checks the package and server automatically. No separate

preflight or manual checksum command is needed.

3 When prompted, open http://ares.local:3001/login, create the first Lesson3 Site Administrator, and store the credentials. Return to the terminal, type READY, then enter the administrator email and password when asked.

4 Wait for ARES Q4 offline installation completed successfully. The installer imports and verifies 95 lesson plans and 806 lessons and installs Tsavo Trust.

5 AnyDesk setup asks for RESET and the standard unattended-access password. Use a local console; reset disconnects AnyDesk sessions. Save the printed ID. If Pending, follow docs/ANYDESK_SETUP.md; retry preserves the new identity. For headless/local desktop support, choose Yes at the LAN desktop activation prompt and set or retain the VNC password. With no Internet, decline the later Tailscale enrollment prompt; LAN access stays active. A support warning does not invalidate a successful core installation. Save the installation log path printed on screen.

6 From another device on the school network, open http://ares.local, check Lesson Plans and the Lesson3 login, and open Tsavo Trust and play a video. Confirm http://ares.local/app_install/index.html opens before setting up teacher phones.

If the package check fails, copy the complete ZIP again and extract it into a new

folder. For any other installation failure, stop and send ARES support the printed

installation log. Do not run individual component installers to work around it.

Remote-support preparation is attempted after the core installation succeeds.

It may require additional server prerequisites; its failure leaves the completed

offline installation usable. ARES support can arrange preparation and activation

later. Preparation preserves existing support services. For offline activation,

run sudo ares-enable-remote-access --lan-only in a normal terminal or LAN SSH.

Connect the technician computer to the school LAN and use

<SERVER-LAN-IP>::5901 in the VNC viewer with the VNC password. No monitor,

Internet or Tailscale is required after setup; the desktop service starts at boot.

Save this connection for on-site visits.

For off-site support, run sudo ares-enable-remote-access with Internet available.

Press Enter at the school-name prompt to keep its hostname. Activation configures

browser SSH and private VNC forwarding automatically. Keep Tailscale connected

on Windows, open a saved VNC connection

to the school's Tailscale address on port 5901 and enter the VNC password. No

PowerShell tunnel is needed. Browser SSH alone does not connect Windows apps to

Tailscale. See docs/REMOTE_ACCESS.md.

The bundled Internet Lockdown v1.4.2 project is prepared afterward, with activation

and reboot persistence left as separate choices. Commands install with no

active adapter; the first lockdown-internet run after connection asks for the

actual student-side LAN. restore-internet does not require LAN selection. Existing active or boot-enabled lockdown is

preserved and its upgrade is deferred; optional remote preparation is also

deferred in that case. If setup needs prerequisites or later attention, core

ARES installation remains successful. See docs/INTERNET_LOCKDOWN.md and the

supplied operating PDF under /opt/ares/internet-lockdown/ares-lockdown-v1.4.2/.

Initial release acceptance is handled by ARES build/support staff using

docs/PROFILE_ACCEPTANCE.md and docs/LESSON3_V094_ACCEPTANCE.md. Technicians do

not repeat the build qualification procedure at each school. A warning alone is

not evidence of failure; an installation error or failed browser check needs support.

2. Generate the one-time installation key

1. On a trusted staff device with Internet access, open https://areseducation.org/monitor_upload/staff_enrollment.php and sign in with the shared staff enrollment password.
2. Search for the school and confirm its name and School ID match the installed server.
3. Select **Generate one-time code**. Keep the displayed XXXX-XXXX installation key private and use it for the intended phone.
4. Sign out when finished. Each additional phone or reinstallation needs a new installation key.

The teacher guide calls this an **installation key**. The app or staff portal may call it an **enrollment code**. They are the same one-time value.

If an unused key already exists, replace it only if the earlier key is lost or

must be revoked. If staff sign-in fails, contact ARES administration; the portal

password is separate from Ubuntu, Lesson3, AnyDesk and VNC passwords.

3. Install ARES Sync from the school server

1. Connect the teacher's Android phone to the local ARES or ARES2 school network.
2. In Chrome, open http://ares.local/app_install/index.html.
3. Tap **Download ARES Sync for Android**.
4. Open ares-sync.apk from the download notification or browser Downloads list.
5. If Android blocks installation from Chrome or Files, open the offered Settings page and enable **Allow from this source** only for the app being used to open the APK.
6. Allow a Play Protect/app scan if offered. Do not disable Play Protect globally.
7. Tap **Install**, then **Open**.

The APK download and installation can be completed while the school has no Internet connection.

4. Enroll the phone

1. If enrollment requires central verification, connect the phone to normal Internet or enable mobile data before this step.
2. In ARES Sync, find and select the exact school.
3. Enter the one-time installation key from ARES staff.
4. Select **Enroll this phone**.
5. If enrollment fails, verify the selected school, Internet availability, and code. Do not generate multiple replacement keys blindly.

5. Approve school-network access

After enrollment, approve the Android prompts required by ARES Sync:

- network suggestions;

- Nearby Wi-Fi devices (or the older Android Location-equivalent permission);

- ARES or ARES2 connection approval if requested; and

- notifications.

Wait for setup to return to the main screen.

6. Verify the completed installation

Before leaving, confirm that the app shows the correct school and a normal ready/up-to-date state. Also verify that the server's usage-collection endpoint and report generation remain operational.

Teacher explanation

Explain that ARES Sync normally works in the background. On scheduled collection dates it obtains the school's usage-summary file from the local ARES server. When normal Internet later becomes available, it sends any pending file securely to ARES Education.

Tell the teacher:

- Keep ARES Sync installed and notifications enabled.

- A new phone or reinstallation requires a new one-time installation key.

- Contact the ARES Advocate if the app shows the wrong school, repeatedly needs attention, or fails to return to the ready state.

- The local page http://ares.local/app_install/index.html is for installing/reinstalling ARES Sync while connected to the school ARES network.

Quick troubleshooting

ares.local/app_install/index.html **does not open**

- Confirm the phone is connected to ARES or ARES2.

- On the server, test curl -I -H 'Host: ares.local' http://127.0.0.1/app_install/index.html.

- Confirm /mnt/sda3/var/www/app_install/index.html exists.

APK will not download

- Confirm /mnt/sda3/var/www/downloads/ares-sync.apk exists and is nonempty.

- Test curl -I -H 'Host: ares.local' http://127.0.0.1/downloads/ares-sync.apk.

Android will not install the APK

- Confirm it came from the local ARES server.

- Allow installation from the specific browser/Files source when Android asks.

- Complete the recommended app scan.

- Do not disable Play Protect globally.

Enrollment fails

- The offline APK installation may be complete even when enrollment cannot yet reach the central ARES service.

- Restore normal Internet/mobile data, verify the exact school, and retry the same valid code before issuing another one.